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The Gangster Anti-Hero as a Cue for Public Critical Engagement in Mapantsula

Mapantsula (1988), directed by Oliver Schmitz, is often classified as an anti-apartheid film due to its setting in the final years of apartheid South Africa and its focus on police brutality, political repression, and resistance. However, unlike many anti-apartheid films that foreground collective struggle and heroic political activists, *Mapantsula* centres its narrative on a small-time criminal named Panic. The film draws heavily on the conventions of the gangster genre and places a pantsula, rather than an activist, at its core. This generic choice is not incidental. It fundamentally shapes the film's political intervention.

This essay argues that *Mapantsula* uses the gangster anti-hero to cue public critical engagements with both apartheid and anti-apartheid politics. By presenting Panic as an apolitical gangster whose survival depends on self-interest, style, and detachment, the film exposes the contradictions of apartheid society and probes the limits of individualism under systemic oppression. Panic's gradual political awakening does not follow the familiar trajectory of heroic conversion. Instead, it emerges from personal loss, coercive state power, and the collapse of his gangster survival logic. Through this process, the film positions the audience to critically engage not only with the violence of apartheid, but also with the ethical demands and exclusions of organised resistance.

The essay will begin by outlining the gangster genre as a cinematic framework, drawing on McWilliams identification of genre, Govender's analysis of the gangster genre in the South African context, and discuss why the genre is particularly suited to social critique. It will then situate *Mapantsula* within the broader landscape of anti-apartheid cinema, contrasting its use of an anti-hero with more conventional representations of political struggle. Following a brief synopsis, the essay will provide a close analysis of two key sequences: the opening sequence that establishes Panic's gangster identity, and the later sequence following Sam's arrest that marks Panic's political crisis. These sequences will be analysed through McArthur's three visual categories of the gangster genre: physical presence, urban setting, and technology. Finally, the essay will show how Panic's role as a gangster anti-hero functions not to produce a satisfying heroic resolution, but to prompt critical public engagement with apartheid and anti-apartheid politics.

To understand the cinematic work performed by *Mapantsula*, it is necessary to consider the role of genre. According to McWilliams (2007:218), genre refers to the classification of films into recognisable groups based on shared conventions, themes, and stylistic patterns. Genre texts operate through established codes that create expectations for audiences, while also allowing filmmakers to revise or subvert those expectations. Genres are therefore not fixed categories but dynamic frameworks through which social meanings are produced and contested.

The gangster genre has long functioned as a vehicle for social critique. As Shadoian (2003:3) notes, the gangster film genre remains a viable framework for articulating aspects of the socioeconomic world that audiences may find uncomfortable or prefer to ignore. Traditionally, gangster narratives focus on individuals who exist outside the law, navigating hostile urban environments through violence, cunning, and self-interest. These characters often embody contradictions, simultaneously displaying ambition, charisma, and moral ambiguity. As a result, the gangster genre is well-suited to exploring themes of power, inequality, and the blurred boundaries between legality and justice. It is within this framework that Mapantsula must be situated and, crucially, distinguished from the anti-apartheid films that preceded it.

Anti-apartheid films occupy a distinctive and politically charged position within South African cinema. Many films produced during and about apartheid approached the political struggle through narratives of heroism and collective resistance. These films are often centred on politically conscious protagonists, organised movements, and clearly defined moral oppositions. Alvarez (1997:103) notes that in such films, Black characters were reduced to unfortunate victims of state violence, inspirational political figures, or anonymous protestors representations designed to build international sympathy rather than examine the lived complexity of Black township life. An example of this is *Cry Freedom* (1987), directed by Richard Attenborough, a biographical drama focused on the life of the Black Consciousness leader Steve Biko. The film positions the audience alongside a heroic political figure and presents apartheid as a clearly identifiable enemy to be opposed through moral conviction and activism.

This mode of representation offers clarity and inspiration, but it also tends to simplify political experience. By foregrounding heroes and collective struggle, such films can marginalise the perspectives of those who do not immediately identify with organised resistance, including individuals whose lives are shaped by poverty, crime, or political ambivalence. In contrast, *Mapantsula* shifts the political lens. Rather than presenting a committed activist, it follows Panic, a character whose primary concern is personal survival within an oppressive system.

By refusing to centre heroism, *Mapantsula* complicates the relationship between individual experience and political struggle. “Mapantsula departs from previous fictional anti-apartheid films in that the transformation in the protagonist's character and outlook is depicted as gradual rather than epiphanic” (Alvarez, 1997:115). The film does not deny the importance of organised resistance, but it questions how political consciousness forms and what it demands of those who have learned to survive through detachment. This difference is crucial to understanding the film’s political impact and its use of the gangster anti-hero as a device for critical engagement.

According to McArthur (1972, quoted by Govender, 2011:40), three categories are central to the visual iconography of the gangster film: physical presence, urban settings, and the technology at the gangster's disposal. Physical presence includes clothing, gesture, and bodily confidence, which communicate dominance and threat. The urban milieu emphasises environments of instability, surveillance, and danger. Technology encompasses tools such as guns, cars, and other instruments that enable mobility and control within the city. These elements combine to situate the gangster as a figure shaped by, and reacting against, hostile social conditions in the film *Mapantsula*.

Mapantsula follows the life of Panic, a small-time hustler who survives through petty theft, intimidation, and informal dealings. Panic prides himself on avoiding political involvement and believes that his individual strategies can shield him from the state's violence. He dresses sharply, moves confidently through urban spaces, and distances himself from both white authority and black collective identity. This position becomes untenable when Panic is arrested during a political protest and imprisoned with anti-apartheid activists. Through flashbacks prompted by interrogation, the film reveals his past relationships, criminal activities, and moments of moral compromise.

To properly understand Panic's role as a gangster anti-hero, it is necessary to consider the cultural meaning of the pantsula. Mapantsula is identified as a subcultural response to the alienation of township life under apartheid, marked by stylised speech, distinctive dress, and a confident, swaggering presence. This identity served as a way for marginalised individuals, often ex-convicts excluded from economic and political systems, to assert themselves by using performance, style, and intimidation to claim symbolic power rather than formal authority (Tomaselli, 1991:52-53).

This definition is crucial for understanding Panic as an anti-hero. Unlike the classical political hero of anti-apartheid cinema, Panic does not articulate a clear ideology or possess a collective political vision. His pantsula identity aligns him closely with the gangster figure, which, according to Govender (2011:42), is defined by flashy, exaggerated confidence, typically expressed through formal clothing like suits, polished shoes, and hats worn with deliberate, stylish details such as a precise tilt. Panic's significance lies precisely in this marginal position. This enables the film to examine apartheid's consequences not through ideological commitment, but through everyday criminal survival. Two sequences in particular carry the weight of this argument.

The first sequence, drawn from the film's opening flashbacks, establishes Panic's identity prior to his arrest, foregrounding moments that reveal his relationship to space, work, authority, and community, including the robbery of a white man, interactions at the shebeen, his conversation with Sam, and his visit to Pat's workplace. The second sequence, unfolding shortly before and after his arrest, confronts Panic with the political consequences he has previously avoided, most notably through scenes

involving Sam's detention and death, the burned school, his confrontation with Duma, his arrest during township unrest, and his entry into the prison cell alongside political detainees. These sequences do not simply mark narrative progression. Together, they provide the primary visual and thematic material through which *Mapantsula* mobilises the gangster genre to produce critical engagement with apartheid and anti-apartheid politics and provide the visual and thematic material through which McArthur's(1972) three categories of the gangster genre can now be examined.



(Figure 1&2: Panic's style)

In *Mapantsula*, the category of physical presence operates as a visible performance of independence that allows the gangster anti-hero to survive temporarily under apartheid, while simultaneously masking his political vulnerability. Panic's body, dress, and posture initially function as tools of control and separation, but the film gradually exposes these same traits as insufficient once political reality intrudes.

This is evident in the first sequence of flashbacks, where Panic's carefully styled formal clothing and relaxed bodily confidence allow him to dominate public space without state intervention, as shown in figures 1 and 2. In the robbery of the white man and the intimidation of township boys playing dice, Panic relies on posture, gaze, and composure. These scenes activate McArthur's category precisely: Panic's body signals threat, authority, and distinction. Importantly, this physical confidence is not directed at challenging apartheid power, but at asserting personal autonomy within it. Panic's body becomes the site through which he performs the fantasy of being unaffected by the system.



(Figure 3:Panic's reaction to the comrade's confusion) VS (Figure4: The comrades reaction to Panic's greeting)

However, the second sequence demonstrates the breakdown of this physical authority. When Panic enters the prison cell and greets the comrades with “Heita” instead of political slogans, his body no longer produces recognition or fear. The same bodily strategies that functioned effectively in the streets are rendered meaningless in the prison cell with comrades. Through this contrast, the film proves that physical presence, while central to the gangster genre, works in *Mapantsula* as a fragile survival mechanism rather than a stable source of power. Panic’s anti-hero status emerges precisely from this fragility. His body reveals how apartheid produces subjects who learn to survive through performance, only to discover that such performances cannot withstand political confrontation.

The second category: urban milieu functions as a space of conditional mobility for the gangster anti-hero, granting Panic movement and agency only as long as he remains politically disengaged. The city initially appears navigable through individual skill and confidence, but the film gradually exposes this mobility as an illusion sustained by denial rather than power. This operation of space is evident in the first sequence of flashbacks. Panic moves with ease through township streets, shebeens, buses, and even white suburban environments. His ability to rob a white man in public, intimidate township boys, spend leisure time at the shebeen, and enter Pat’s workplace without visible fear suggests that urban space can be managed through street intelligence and bravado. Panic’s conversation with Sam, where he dismisses wage labour and gestures toward commuters running for taxis, reinforces this illusion of freedom. The city is framed as a place one can outsmart rather than submit to.

However, the second sequence exposes the limits of this mobility. This interrupts Panic’s ordinary movement through the city and confronts him with the reality that apartheid violence penetrates everyday spaces, not only sites of activism. As the sequence progresses, chase scenes, police presence, and teargas replace free movement. Panic’s arrest during township unrest confirms that urban space is ultimately controlled by the apartheid state, not negotiated by individual survival strategies. Through this spatial transformation, the film demonstrates that the gangster anti-hero’s access to the city is temporary and politically contingent. Marco (2021:76) argues that the city initially appears navigable through individual skill and bravado, but the second sequence exposes this mobility as an illusion sustained by political avoidance, once politics enters Panic's life, space closes in around him. In this way, *Mapantsula* uses urban space to critique the fantasy of neutrality and to show that disengagement is not a sustainable response to systemic oppression.

The third category, technology, traditionally refers to the tools that enable the gangster’s power within the urban environment (Govender, 2011:47). In *Mapantsula*, this category operates through inversion. The confrontation between the gangster and the instrument of authority is fully present,

but the technology belongs entirely to the apartheid state. Panic's lack of access to instruments exposes the fragility of the gangster anti-hero's supposed power.

Across the first sequence, Panic's authority is embodied rather than technological. He carries only a knife as a weapon and controls situations through intimidation, posture, and confidence. This absence of gangster technology initially appears inconsequential. Panic's success reinforces the belief that bodily dominance and cleverness are sufficient for survival. The second sequence dismantles this belief. The interrogation scenes place Panic in a technological environment governed by paperwork, files, uniforms, and the threat of torture. These are technologies of control that cannot be negotiated or performed against. Panic's gangster skills are rendered useless. He cannot intimidate a file, charm an interrogation room, or dance his way out of a confession. The police station becomes the ultimate space in which individual survival strategies collapse.

This technological imbalance transforms the gangster anti-hero into a figure of exposure. Panic's refusal to sign the confession gains significance not because it restores his power, but because it happens in a space where power is overwhelmingly absent. The film thus uses technology to reveal the structural limitations of gangster individualism under apartheid. The state's instruments extract submission, and Panic's resistance emerges not from mastery, but from reaching a moral limit.

Beyond McArthur's visual categories, Govender (2011) notes that *Mapantsula* engages the gangster genre through a reworking of Robert Warshow's rise-and-fall narrative structure. Classical gangster films chart a protagonist's ascent to power followed by inevitable downfall, often culminating in death (Govender, 2011:48). *Mapantsula* rejects this structure materially while preserving it politically. Panic never rises economically, never accumulates wealth, and never controls a gang.






(Figure5: Panic in sequence 1 vs Figure 6&7: Panic in Sequence 2)

Instead, Panic's rise is emotional and political. The first sequence positions him at the height of his confidence as a gangster anti-hero. He appears in control of his environment, dismissive of authority, and insulated from political consequence. This is his "rise", but it is built on avoidance rather than power. The second sequence stages Panic's fall. This fall is not marked by death or punishment, but by forced awareness. Sam's detention and death, the arrest, and the interrogation dismantle Panic's survival logic. His final refusal to cooperate with the authorities does not restore status or guarantee

safety. It marks a loss. A loss of neutrality, a loss of illusion, and a loss of the gangster fantasy that one can exist outside politics. By reworking the rise-and-fall structure in this way, *Mapantsula* transforms the gangster anti-hero into a vehicle for political critique. Panic's trajectory does not reward him. It implicates him.

All of this comes together in the figure of Panic as an anti-hero. Mapantsula uses its gangster genre framework to do something quite specific: it places a Pantsula at the centre of an anti-apartheid story, and in doing so, it shifts the ground on which that story is typically told. The elements that the film takes from the gangster genre, the street-level world, the figure defined by style and survival, the anti-hero's complicated relationship with law and authority, are all present in Panic. But they are filtered through the specificity of the Pantsula identity and through the particular social world of Soweto under apartheid. The genre gives the film its shape; the Pantsula gives it its texture.

What Panic's role as a gangster anti-hero makes possible, politically, is a form of engagement that sidesteps the familiar vocabulary of anti-apartheid heroism. The film's significance lies partly in its refusal to make its central character a straightforward embodiment of resistance. Panic does not stand for the liberation movement. He is selfish, petty, sometimes cruel, and yet his final refusal to cooperate with the authorities is, in the context of this film, an act of real moral weight. It is precisely the gap between Panic's established pattern of self-interest and his final refusal that gives the moment its force; an audience familiar with his survival logic would find his defiance unexpected and therefore more politically striking (Alvarez, 1997:111). When an ideologically committed activist refuses to name names, it reads as ideological consistency, admirable, perhaps, but expected. It reads as a human choice made by someone who had every incentive to do otherwise, someone who had spent his whole life avoiding exactly this kind of cost. His refusal cannot be explained by politics. It has to be explained by something more fundamental, by a basic, almost instinctive resistance to being used by the state.

This is where the film's engagement with anti-apartheid politics becomes genuinely complex. Mapantsula does not simply celebrate resistance, it asks its audience to think about where resistance comes from, what it costs, and who it belongs to. By routing this question through a gangster anti-hero rather than a political hero, the film opens a conversation that more conventional anti-apartheid cinema tended to foreclose. The audience cannot simply admire Panic from a comfortable distance. They are asked to understand him, his choices, his vanity, his survival logic, and to follow that understanding all the way to his moment of refusal. In doing so, the film creates a form of critical engagement that is more demanding and, arguably, more honest than the solidarity politics of more straightforwardly political films.

There is also something important in the film's implicit critique of organised resistance itself. Panic's distance from political structures is not simply presented as ignorance or selfishness. The film shows us, through his eyes, that the anti-apartheid movement makes demands on people, demands for sacrifice, loyalty, and solidarity, without necessarily accounting for the full complexity of those people's lives. Panic is not a soldier in anyone's army. His act of refusal is not endorsed by a movement or explained by an ideology. It is his own, and that singularity is part of what makes it meaningful. The film suggests that the question of what apartheid does to ordinary people, not heroes, not activists, but people like Panic, is at least as important as the question of organised resistance. In this sense, the gangster anti-hero is not just a way of making an anti-apartheid film more entertaining. He is the argument.

In conclusion, this essay has argued that *Mapantsula* uses the gangster anti-hero to provoke critical engagement with both apartheid and anti-apartheid politics by centring an apolitical pantsula rather than a heroic activist. Through an analysis of two key sequences using McArthur's gangster categories and Govender's reworking of the rise-and-fall structure, the essay showed how Panic's bodily confidence, urban mobility, and individual survival logic initially allow him to avoid politics, only for these strategies to collapse under state violence and collective resistance. Panic's final refusal to cooperate is not a heroic victory but a costly loss of neutrality, and it is precisely his flawed status as a gangster anti-hero that gives this moment its political force. In this way, *Mapantsula* shifts the focus of anti-apartheid cinema from idealised resistance to the difficult, uneven process through which political consciousness is formed.

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